

Navigating Prenatal Trauma

with Manuela Mischke-Reeds, MFT

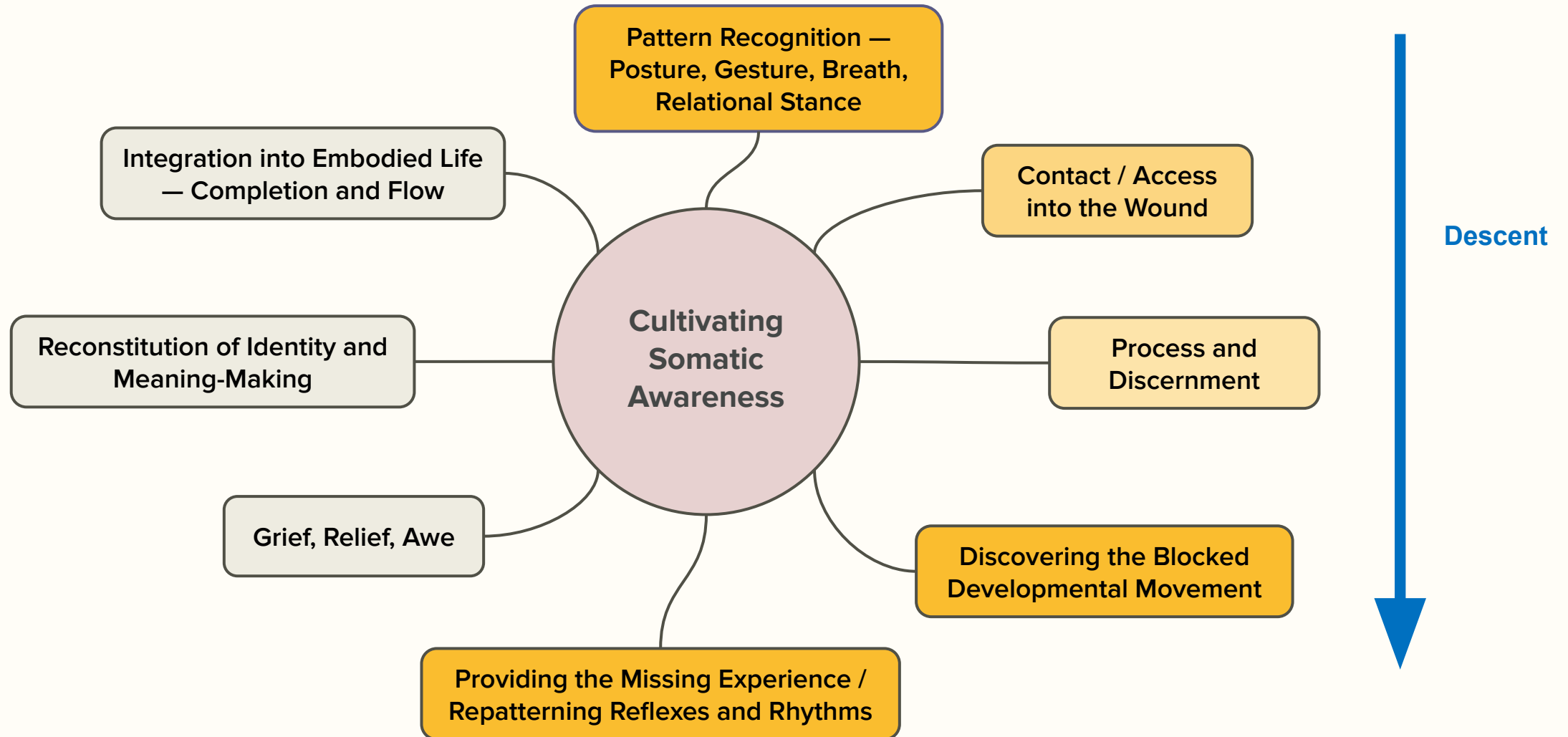




AGENDA

Primal Somatic Rhythms
Non-verbal Attunement
Heart Synchrony Practice
Birth Narrative
Q & A
Breakout Sessions

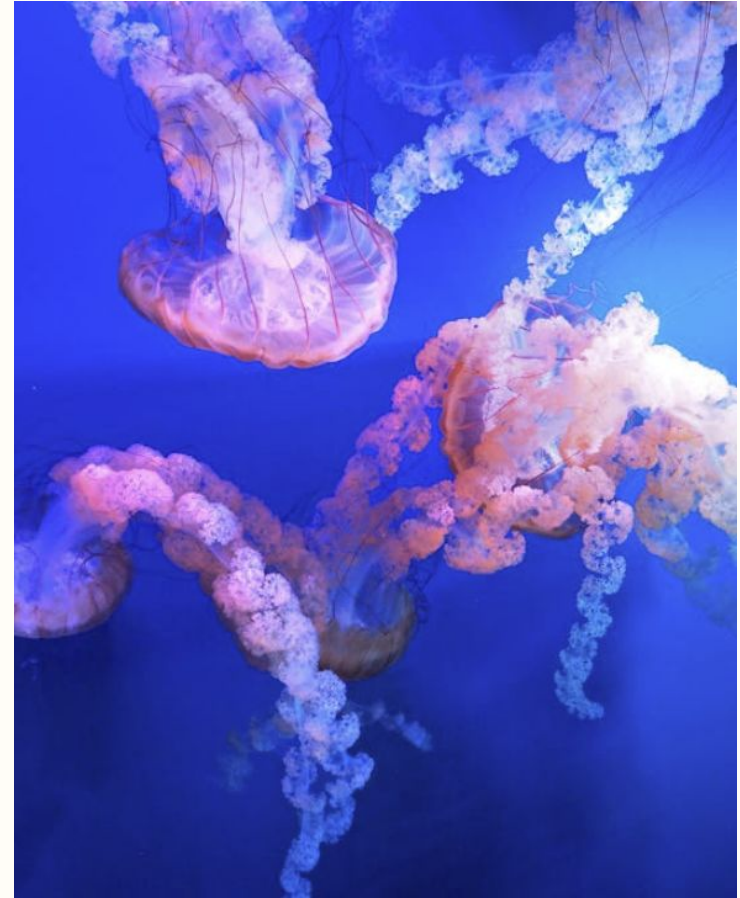
The 8-Phase Map of Developmental Repair



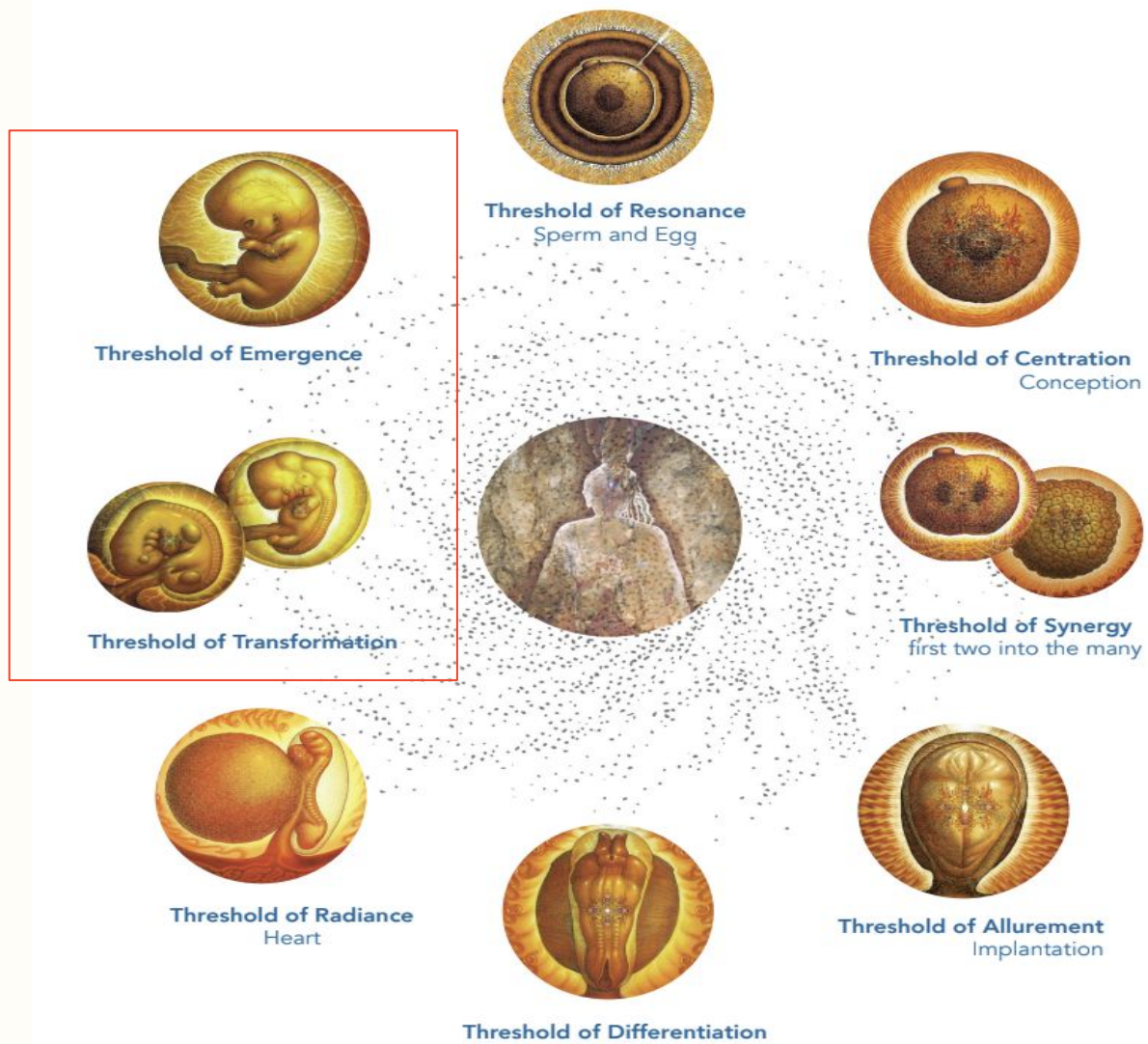
Primal Somatic Rhythms

Rhythms and Non-linear paths

1. Cellular Breathing
2. **Naval Radiation (8-10 week of gestation)**
3. Mouthing
4. Pre-spinal
5. **Birth Spiral**
6. Push-Pull-Reach-Yield Pattern



JOURNEY OF BECOMING

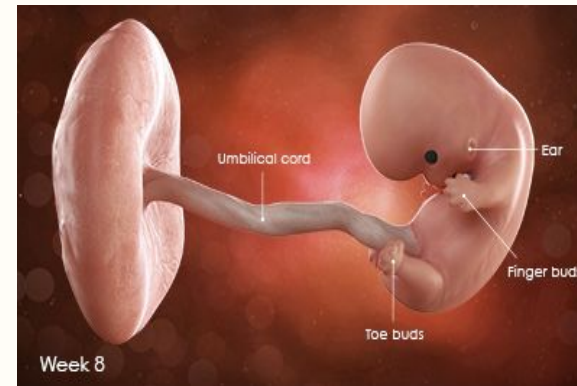


Source: Susan Harper, Images Alex Grey

Exercise: Navel Radiation



Starfish pattern of movement
6 limb motion
Wave like motion: center to periphery





Birth Spiral

The Birth Spiral- Primal Rhythm of Emergence

- Birth Phase: from fluid to compression, containment, rhythmic intensity to emergence
 - Basic life motif: spirals through each passage of life
1. Spiral Descent: head rotates and tilts following the curves of the pelvic bones
 2. Pressure and Release: uterine contraction waves, pressure-rotation-descent-pause
 3. Pause between contraction: Stillness, lingering, inner rhythm
 4. Rotation Pelvic Floor: internal rotation, baby's face turns towards the mothers back. Shoulder angle different than head, spirals through curving birth canal.
 5. Emergence/Crowning: Head extends backward (extension) emerges under pubic bone. Shoulders rotate internal, body follows as a spiral. Body uncoils. Release and emergence

The Birth Spiral Reflection for Clients

- Where in my life do I experience contraction?
- How can I soften into intensity rather than resist?
- How can I trust my body to know how to navigate tight places?
- What rhythms help me navigate through compression (pressure) and intensity?
- How does your spine want to move? (Spiral & curve motif)
- How do I organize around stuckness?

Post Birth Unwinding

- Baby's nervous system unwinds from compression, rhythmic movement and breath
- Uterus contracts, fluids in the mother's body shift and breath deepens and settles
- Both bodies reorganize, restoring developmental integrity

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Heart Synchrony

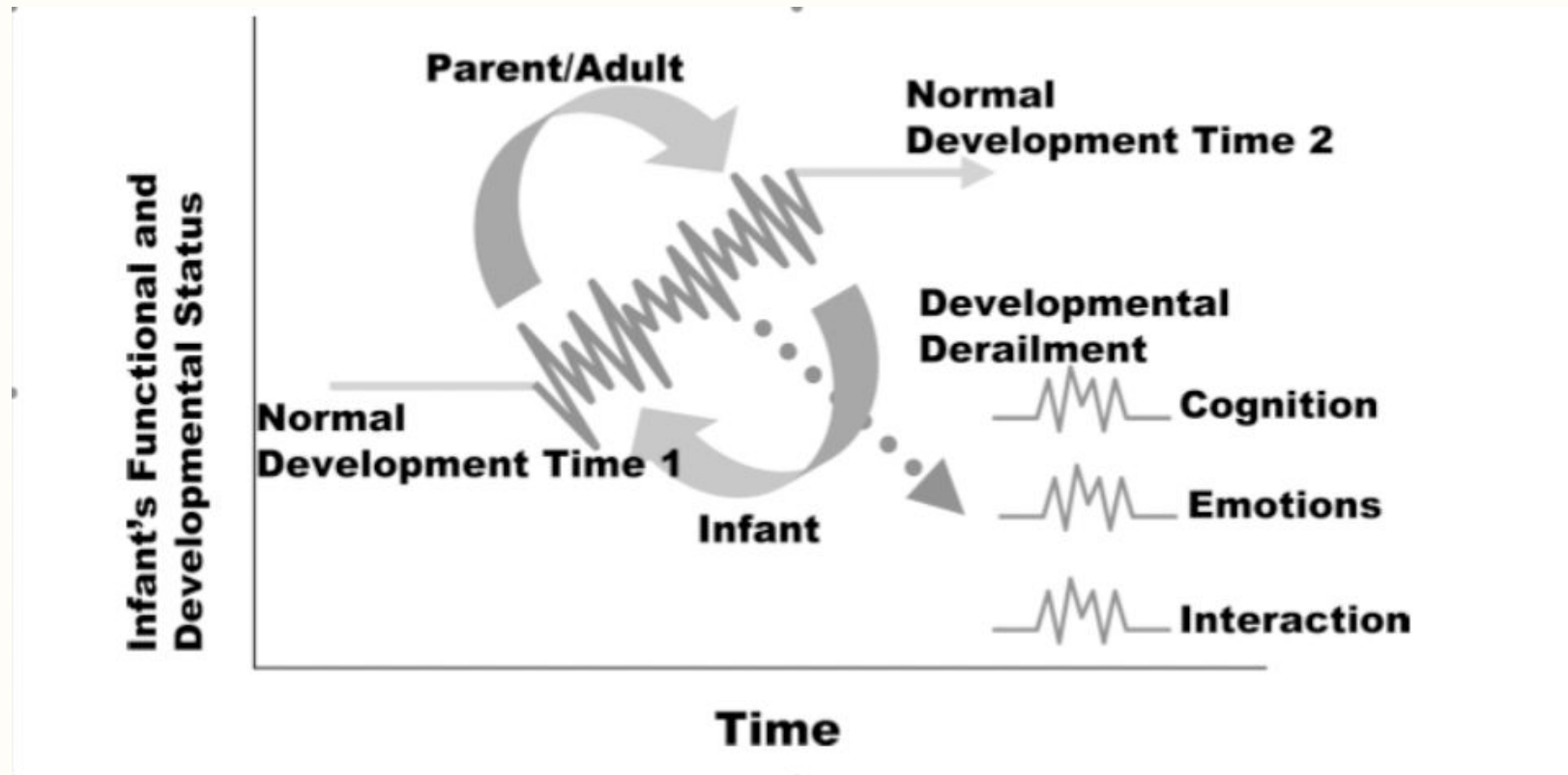
Heart Synchrony

Heart Synchrony is a state in which the heart (HRV) becomes smooth, regular and harmonized with the nervous system/brain functioning

- Chronic relational stress/neglect creates a lack of self-regulation
- Heart and brain communicate continuously
- When NS is dysregulated the heart-rate becomes chaotic
- Therapists own heart coherence effects the the client's inner state

Stress of Normal Development and Resilience

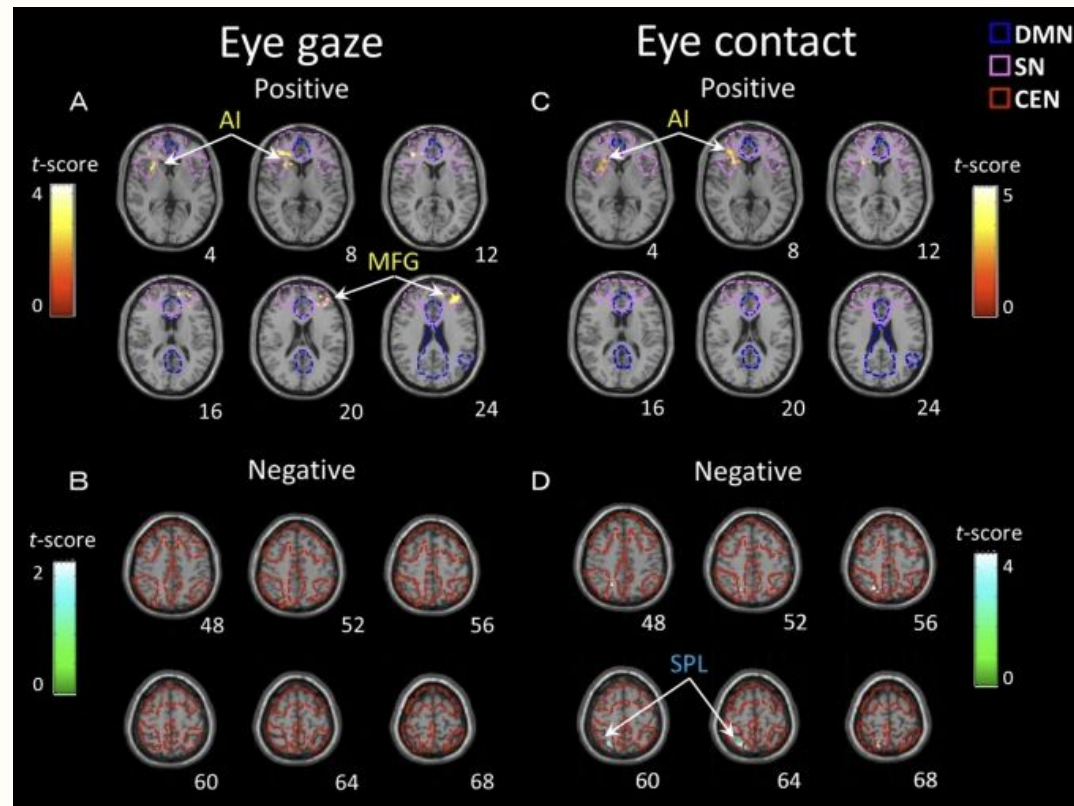
- Normal Development involves disorganization and it will disorganize other functions



Source: Ed Tronick

Eye gaze and intrinsic brain activity

- Gazing & Motherese, affective touch, interactive play



Source: Kuboshita, 2020

Mechanism of Synchrony

Heart Synchrony is influenced:

- Touch and proximity (skin to skin; holding, rocking)
- Voice (prosodic, soothing tones)
- Breath (shared rhythm aligns heart rates)
- Eye contact and facial expression (mirror neuron activation)
- Emotional resonance (shared affective states)

Inconsistent, neglectful caregiving leads to dysregulated heart rhythms and impacts long term health of emotional and stress resilience.



Study of role of touch and proximity of brain and heart rhythms in mothers and babies



Heart Attunement Practice





Exc. Heart Attunement Practice

Application in Therapy

- Breath Coherence practice
- Therapists Self state
- Heart focused attention
- Relational co-regulation
- Tracking Somatic indicators (track elevated heart rates and intervene)
- Contain, soothe and anchor experiences
- Integrate trauma processing with movement, sounds, touch and breath



Birth Narrative

Birth Narrative- Meaning Making

- “Ugly Duckling Story”
- Birth Narratives are tools for meaning making and identity formation and adjustment
- Birth Narratives
 - **The Actual Story-** factual such as C-section, medical emergency etc.
 - What happened? What was shared with you?
 - **The Perceived Story** – Shaped by culture, family, media. Unrealistic expectations or mismatch with internal experience.
 - What was the family/cultural narrative?
 - What is unresolved?
 - **The Felt Story** – internal experience: loss, trauma, fear etc.
 - What surprised you? What meaning do you make of this?



Exc. Birth Narrative

Integration Goals

- Restore sense of agency and safety in the body
- Reconnect with internal rhythms and inner trust
- Integrate emotional and physiological aspects of birth experience
- Support attachment and tend to rupture and repair

Integration Tools

- Repattern birth movements
- Containment work (highly discerning touch work)
- Imaginal felt sense dialogue
- Relational work
- Breath and Vagal regulation
- Grounding and orienting



SLOW and WAIT
Entrain with the rhythm of the client

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QUESTIONS



BREAKOUT SESSIONS

Discussion Prompts

(Note: share what you feel comfortable with and its ok to not disclose sensitive material)

1. Share the birth story as you have been told and your internal somatic sense of your birth?
2. Discuss how you can apply the birth spiral awareness in your therapy work.
3. What was your experience with the Heart Synchrony Practice?

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